

BEST LARGE
NBFC
BAJAJ FINANCE

FIN AI AT THE HELM

Bajaj Finance's leadership, consumer data, and AI are becoming its real moat

BY ANAND ADHIKARI



The Changemaker Rajeev Jain, Vice Chairman and MD, Bajaj Finance

AFTER SPENDING MORE than two decades at the helm, Ratan Tata retired in 2012 as chairman of Tata Sons, but was asked to return in 2016 to restore stability after his successor Cyrus Mistry's sudden exit. At Infosys, N.R. Narayana Murthy, after nearly three decades in the corner room, returned as Executive Chairman in 2013. Globally, Disney turned to Bob Iger, who had exited in 2020 after nearly a decade-and-a-half as the CEO, bringing him back two years later as the entertainment giant grappled with losses. In each case, the return was a stopgap move

aimed at stabilising the institution during a moment of sudden instability.

A similar pattern is unfolding at Bajaj Finance. Rajeev Jain, the professional who transformed the NBFC over nearly one-and-a-half decades as its MD & CEO, had to return to an executive role after the abrupt exit of his successor Anup Saha in 2025. In the absence of a ready successor, the board turned again to Jain, re-designating him as Vice Chairman and MD.

Despite some uncertainty over succession planning over the past few years, the country's largest NBFC—with assets of ₹3.67 lakh crore—has continued to deliver

strong performance. Underscoring this consistency, this Sanjiv Bajaj-run consumer finance major has been ranked the Best Large NBFC in the *BT-KPMG Survey of India's Best Banks & NBFCs* for the third consecutive year.

SUCCESSION AT PLAY

Bajaj Finance's leadership transition resembles the classic GE succession model of the late 90s, when the outgoing CEO Jack Welch famously created a bench of three to four CEO-ready leaders before Jeff Immelt was finally selected. Interestingly, there is a direct GE connection here as well. Jain has previously held senior leadership roles at GE India and